



Freedmen's school

A teacher and her pupils are pictured outside a Freedmen's school in North Carolina. In the 1860s, the Freedmen's Bureau established thousands of such schools for Black children.

Black American citizenship

Northerners might agree that slavery should end, but they debated sharply among themselves what that freedom should mean in regard to former slaves. On the other hand, Black people saw that, along with ownership of land as the basis for economic independence, freedom should include citizenship and the right to vote. The Reconstruction Amendments (Thirteenth, Fourteenth, and Fifteenth) and civil rights legislation effected radical change. Slavery had denied Black Americans their humanity, treating them as a form of property. The Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments went far beyond mere emancipation. They defined freedmen as citizens, guaranteed "equal protection of the law," and outlawed voting discrimination based on color. In addition, state and local